Bank and the IMF have historically provided lenient conditions to secure populist cooperation, as we show in chapter 5. Similarly, the WTO proposed reforms to its voting and procedural structures in response to the Trump administration's criticisms. These measures aim to mollify populist leaders and prevent further disruptions to IO operations.

IOs can also sideline populists' constituents. Populist leaders often face domestic backlash for engaging with IOs, as cooperation can appear inconsistent with their anti-globalist rhetoric. IOs exploit this vulnerability by engaging populists covertly or empowering domestic actors who oppose local populist policies. For example, leaders like Silvio Berlusconi and Hugo Chávez continued to collaborate with the IMF in private while publicly denouncing it. Alternatively, IOs can strengthen domestic counterweights to populist agendas by supporting nonpopulist groups within a country. By fostering alliances with civil society organizations or subnational governments, IOs can create alternative pathways for engagement and diminish populist influence.

Finally, IOs can appease populists' constituents. To reduce populists' ability to leverage anti-IO rhetoric, organizations can work to win over domestic populations. This involves public outreach, emphasizing the tangible benefits that IOs provide, such as foreign aid, infrastructure projects, or economic support. Branding aid projects with IO logos, as seen with many UN initiatives, is one example of how organizations boost their visibility and reputation. IOs may also adopt populist rhetoric themselves, presenting their work as a defense of ordinary citizens against corrupt elites. During the eurocrisis, both the IMF and the EU emphasized how their reforms aimed to reduce corruption and protect everyday citizens in Greece, positioning themselves as allies of the public rather than as distant, elite-driven institutions.

IOs often adopt multipronged responses to populist threats. Rather than rely on a single strategy, they combine approaches in order to maximize their effectiveness. For instance, while appeasing populist leaders may preserve engagement, IOs may simultaneously sideline populist constituents to limit domestic blowback to such cooperation. Similarly, covert collaboration with populists can complement public outreach efforts that seek to boost public support for IOs over the long run.